



Uneasy succession: R. Ashwin's certainty forged India's home dominance. Washington Sundar lacks the craft Ashwin had at a similar stage of his career. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

sweep no one saw coming.

The away spinners matched their Indian opponents in all regards, effectively negating the home side's advantage. While Mitchell Santner dazzled in the second Test in Pune with a 13-wicket haul, Ajaz Patel stepped up at the Wankhede with 11 wickets.

A new-look Indian batting line-up, bereft of the experience of Pujara and Rahane, laboured futilely on sharp-spinning black-soil surfaces.

It also did not help India's cause that its senior batters, Rohit Sharma

and Kohli, endured a chastening series. While the former averaged 15.16, the latter did only fractionally better at 15.50. This is the lowest both have averaged in a home series in which they played at least six innings.

In totality, the seemingly unstoppable Indian ship of home Test superiority had its mast sliced by New Zealand.

South Africa, though, went one step further and overturned the vessel. At the centre of it all was Harmer.

Of the 25 wickets claimed by South African spinners in the series, 17 were Harmer's.

The 36-year-old off-spinner had the ball on a string throughout, toying with Indian batters through his mastery over flight, pace and

length, control earned across a long, winding and tumultuous career.

Experience edge

Thanks to a long stint with Essex in the English county system, Harmer has featured in 236 First-Class games and taken 1,017 wickets. The four Indian spinners combined have only 1,060 FC wickets, with nearly half belonging to Jadeja.

Washington presents the most interesting case of the four. He shares many traits with Ashwin: both hail from the same State, bowl off-spin and possess dogged batting styles. But in terms of off-spin acumen, Washington lacks the craft Ashwin had at a similar stage of his career.

That contrast is natural, considering Washington made his Test debut with a bank of just 12 First-Class matches, yielding 30 wickets. Ashwin, by comparison, had played 34 games and collected 157 wickets before his first Test.

What has worked in Washington's favour is his ability with the bat. From 17 Tests, he has scored 885 runs at an average of 42.14. But his bowling average stands at 32.97. Against South Africa, Washington managed just a solitary wicket, not the output expected from a lead off-spinner.

It is clear that India's selection policy for spinners, and bowlers by extension, heavily factors in their batting. In the away series against England, India benched Kuldeep throughout the five matches.

This stood in contrast to the weight of experience Harmer carried into the series, which included a near-career-ending tour to India in 2015. It can be no coincidence that Harmer, Maharaj and Ajaz all carried bruising memories of touring India in the past. With failure came experience, and with that, a blueprint for success.

Without taking anything away from him, it would be fair to say that Harmer's imperiousness was magnified by the Indian batters' glaring inability to handle the turning ball.

Batting rigidities

Since 2020, Indian batters have averaged just 35.26 against spin in